

HIGH DRAMA OVER HIGH OFFICE

The UPA-Left's plans to have the country's first woman president face a credible challenge as the BJP-led NDA and the born-again Third Front prop up incumbent Abdul Kalam for a second term. Suddenly, the presidential election is no longer a walkover.

■ By Priya Sahgal and Satarupa Bhattacharjya

Last week, a magazine cartoon showed a "To Let" sign outside Rashtrapati Bhavan with the tagline saying: 'Contact Sonia Gandhi'. That was when the nomination of Pratibha Patil as the country's next and first woman president seemed a walk in the Rose Garden. She, and Sonia, should have known that nothing in Indian politics is certain. Even as Patil was making the rounds of political leaders and adding to her collection of bouquets, came a surprise twist in the tale, this time from the man who still resides in the imperial mansion atop Raisina Hill: outgoing President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam.

The "To Let" sign now had acquired a host of sub-agents, from the NDA stable. The so-called Third Front was in the vanguard of the political battle that threatened to make it a straight contest between Kalam, who had agreed to a second term if there was "certainty" of his winning, and Patil, who had the numbers and Sonia's blessings. Even though the introduction of Kalam was a masterstroke—he had certainly a better chance than the (BJP's) independent candidate, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat—it did hint of a desperate attempt to put the Congress and the ruling UPA on the back foot. They may have succeeded in that limited objective, but in the larger game of who would be India's next president, only two entities could have swung the battle Kalam's way: The Left and Mayawati. Both, of course, said 'no'.

Almost overnight, the equations had

changed. According to a Rashtrapati Bhavan statement, at the end of Kalam's meeting with the Third Front leaders, the president told them that he was willing to wait for a few more days for the "certainty" to emerge. "As there is overwhelming love and affection of the people from different parts of the country, I can accept the presidency for a second term provided there is a certainty." Jubilant Third Front leaders rushed to former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee to inform him. The chief Chandrababu Naidu called Congress President Sonia Gandhi and asked her for a consensus around Kalam's name. Gandhi bluntly told him that it was too late. It was perhaps with a sense of political quid pro quo that Sonia echoed the 'too late' phrase back to the Opposition. This is what Vajpayee and leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani had said to her just a few days ago when she asked them to support Patil as the first woman president. Sonia also reminded Naidu that when the Congress wanted to field K.R. Narayanan for a second term, the NDA's response then was to remind them about the convention of the presidential tenure being limited to one term.

Naidu and other Third Front leaders were not about to give up, and on Thursday morning reached CP(M) headquarters seeking support for Kalam. After a brief interaction with party general secretary Prakash Karat, Naidu emerged to announce to the media that Karat had promised to discuss the matter with his politburo

SISTER ACT: Sonia Gandhi takes Pratibha Patil down the presidential path; Kalam (right) changes his mind

